

Confession of Sin

This lesson is the seventh in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions in the back answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”***

Colossians 2:6

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INTRODUCTION

In First John 1:7-10, the Bible says, “But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship one with another, and the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin. If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness. If we say that we have not sinned, we make him a liar, and his word is not in us.”

We have been in the series the “Beginners Bible Study” talking about things that are basic foundational truths for a Christian’s life when they first get saved. Yet these lessons are not just for the new Christians. These are things that we need to constantly remind ourselves of, truths that are important for our own personal Christian growth.

As we talk about confession of sin in this lesson, pay careful attention. I know most of you who have been saved any length of time can probably quote many of the Scriptures that I am going to give you. Maybe you even know everything that I am going to say. Yet, how often do we need to be reminded of the truths that are very basic in the Christian life so we do not forget the things that helped us begin to grow. Those are the things, also, that will help us continue to grow.

When God saved us, He put us into His family. In John 10, I would like to read you a few verses as a foundation and a beginning point of our lesson. We will begin reading in verse 27. *“My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me: And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck*

them out of my hand. My Father which gave them me, is greater than all; and no man is able to pluck them out of my Father's hand."

That is a great foundational truth. We have talked before about the fact that when you trust Christ as your personal Savior, you are placed into the family of God. When you are placed into the family of God and you are related to the Lord Jesus Christ. You are then held by God in such a way that you can never be plucked out of His hand. You can never lose that relationship with the Father. You can never lose your salvation. You can never come to a time or to a place, according to the Word of God, when there is any chance that you could ever be cast out of Heaven and be cast into Hell. You could never come to a place where you would ever be separated from God in the sense that He would say, "You are not mine, I do not want you!" That could never take place.

ILLUSTRATIONS

When you and I were first saved, we were put into that family. It is a picture much like when you were born into your **physical family**. When you were born into your physical family, your parents could have denied you, they could have said, "I am going to disinherit this child." They could have put you up for adoption, but there is one thing they could never do. They could never "unborn" you. They could never make you to be born into a different family than the one you were born into. Your parents are still your parents, and there is no way they can ever get around that.

When you and I are **born into the family of God**, God the Father becomes our Father. We are related to the Lord Jesus Christ by the new birth. We can never be taken out of that family. I know there are some folks today who say, "That's not a very important doctrine." But friend, if you take that doctrine away from what you

believe you no longer have Bible doctrine, and you no longer have Bible salvation. You have the false kind of gospel that the Bible doesn't talk about.

If we can never lose our salvation once we are truly saved, why then is it really important that we confess our sins? Here again, the picture of a family relationship can be used. In **marriage**, you have a husband or a wife, and you have a commitment to them. That commitment is to love them until you die. It is a commitment that as long as you are alive, as long as they are alive, you will belong to one another. You will never violate that trust with another person. It is your wife or your husband that you have committed yourself to.

But, let's be honest. Although there is that commitment and you intend to keep it no matter what, there is still the possibility that from time to time you will have days when you don't get along very well. But in a true family relationship, you have a commitment to that wife, or you have a commitment to that husband. It is a real commitment. It is one that you intend to keep, no matter what.

There are times in the relationship when one party has offended the other, and has sinned against the other, yet there is still a real relationship. It is still a commitment, but the fellowship is not what it once was. The friendship, the coziness, and the intimacy that was once there is not there anymore. The relationship is somewhat strained. The only way you can overcome that straining and bring that friendship and fellowship back and put that closeness back in that marriage is for the offending party to go to the one that has been offended and say, "I've wronged you and I'm sorry, please forgive me!" Now, if you are not big enough to do that, you are destined to have a relationship with that person that is a stormy relationship and a problem relationship at times.

Sadly, our illustration breaks down right here. Because when husbands and wives don't get along over a period of time, eventually they say, "I am throwing this whole relationship out the window. I quit! I am walking away from it." And they go down to the divorce court and they get divorced. But there is one thing they can never do. They can never have it erased from the books that they were married. They can never say that it never happened. In God's eyes, if a man and a woman marry, it is for life. That is God's intention.

You know, that is the kind of a God we have. When He saved us He made us a promise, a pledge, that He would never walk out on us. The reason a husband walks out on a wife, or a wife walks out on a husband is because of sinful actions and sinful reactions. But I am glad to know that I have a God who never sins. I have a God who never does wrong. I have a God who always tells the truth and when He makes a promise, He always keeps it. When I got saved back in 1971, I had the promise and it is still just as true tonight. When God saved me, He said that I would always be in His family. But even though I am in His family and I'll always be His child, I can still sin against God, and I can still break that close tie of friendship and fellowship we have. That is why I need to confess my sins.

INSTRUCTION

Confession of sin does not get me into heaven. As a child of God I have already been saved. I already know Christ as my Savior, and I have been born again. If that hasn't happened to you the rest of this message does not apply. But if you have been born again, you are the one I am speaking to in this message. When you got saved, God intended to continue a life of fellowship with you. He wants to be your friend. He wants to fellowship with you. He wants to be close to you. He wants to have an intimate relationship with you. But that

can only take place if your sins are taken care of promptly, and in the way God says they ought to be. I have three statements to leave with you and I would like to give them to you one at a time.

Christians Will Sin

Number one, You will sin. The Bible teaches in Matthew 6:24, “*No man can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will hold to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mammon.*”

You and I have to make a choice in our Christian lives. We have been saved; yet the fact is there are two masters that we can choose to serve. We can serve the Lord or we can serve the world, it is our choice. One of the marks of our having been born again is that we are not going to choose the world consistently. If we choose it consistently, there is a serious question as to whether or not there has ever been a work of grace done in our heart.

The apostle Paul talked in Romans 7 about a law warring in his members. When he wanted to do that which was right there was another law warring in his members that wanted to draw him off into sin. And the things he wanted to do, he did not do, and the things he did not want to do, he wound up doing them from time to time. Paul cries out at the end of that chapter in verse 24 and says, “*O wretched man that I am! who shall deliver me from the body of this death?*”

Even a great man like the apostle Paul who knew what it was to be a child of God, saved, forgiven of his sin with a home in heaven, also knew what it was to turn his back on the Lord Jesus Christ, the One that had bought him. And at times, he would hurt the Lord and offend Him by turning his back on God and sinning against Him.

You will sin. You will sin as a Christian. You mark it down! Even though you have been born again there will still be times when you will go against the will of God in your life. That is not God's desire. That is not God's will. And if you have really been saved, that won't be your desire, either. If it is your desire, there is something drastically wrong.

I Corinthians 3:1 talks this truth, too. *"And I, brethren, could not speak unto you as unto spiritual, but as unto carnal, even as unto babes in Christ."* A spiritual Christian is one who is saturated with the Word of God and wants to live in obedience to the Word of God. Spiritual Christians have placed their lives under the authority of the Bible and whatever the Bible says. They may not understand it all, but there is one commitment they have made. It is this: As they see Bible truth they are going to obey it.

You will sin, though. Notice what Paul says about a carnal Christian. That is one who knows the truth but doesn't obey it. He is one who knows there are areas in their life they ought to surrender, and they won't do it. In I Corinthians 3:2 he says, *"I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able. For ye are carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men?"* Here were some Christians who had not grown to the place where they could even feed themselves.

It is cute to see a baby. You carry them around, you feed them, you basically take care of all their needs. But you expect that as they grow up, they will be able to take care of those needs on their own.

Sadly, there are people who claim to be Christians who have been born again but are still having to be fed with milk. Paul says a carnal

Christian is one who hasn't learned to grow and hasn't learned to feed himself. This person is characterized by immaturity, impatience, ingratitude, impulsiveness, ignorance, and insensitivity. All these things are talked about in the book of I Corinthians. That's where these people were. They had come to a place where they wanted to do things their way and they did not care about God's way.

You will sin. There will be times when you will be selfish in your life and determine you are going to do things your way instead of God's way. But you mark it down, you will not be satisfied, as a child of God, to live that kind of a life.

Christians Will Be Chastised When They Sin

The first truth, You will sin. But number two, You will be chastised as a child of God. In Hebrews 12 the Lord promises to chastise us as Christians. Chastisement in a Christian's life has often been likened to using a rod in a child's life. When a child does something wrong, you pull out your rod, or your paddle, or your belt or whatever else you may use in order to correct him. But that is not the only kind of correction there is in the Word of God, nor is that the only kind of correction that you use with your children.

When God deals with us, there are different kinds of chastisement He uses in our lives. The first way God deals with us is He speaks to us through the **Word of God** in our hearts. In other words He lets us know, "That isn't right!" We get that uneasy feeling inside and we say, "You know, I didn't do right," or "That wasn't quite right." The first thing we normally do as a young Christian is try to ignore it. "Well, I did wrong that time, the next time I'll try to do better." But God is not happy with that and it will break your fellowship

with Him. When you and I sin against God, God expects us to confess our sins. If we don't confess our sins God will let us know that we have wronged Him.

The Lord is going to deal with us first in our heart and let us know that it is not right. But if that doesn't get our attention and we say, "I'm going to ignore this thing and I'll do better the next time," God is going to keep working in our lives until we recognize what we did is sin and we let Him know we agree with Him that we were wrong. When we do that, He'll forgive us. But until then He is going to begin to work in our lives in more obvious ways.

If God can't get our attention by speaking to us through **the preaching**, through the **reading of the Word of God**, through **calling Scripture to memory**, or through our **conscience**, He will do **something else** in our life. It may be something like what happened in David's life. David lost a baby in order for God to get his attention. It may be that God will have to take your job from you. It may be financial pressures. It may be some relationship problems. There are many different ways God can work and move in order to slap you back into reality, to wake you up and have you say, "Wait a minute, something is not right in my life." That is what He is trying to do.

There are six things in Hebrews 12 I want to note with you about this business of being chastised. Hebrews 12:5 says, "*And ye have forgotten the exhortation which speaketh unto you as unto children, My son, despise not thou the chastening of the Lord, nor faint when thou art rebuked of him.*"

The first lesson we find is that **we should not rebel against God**. God is telling us here, when He chastises us, when He speaks to us

in our heart or brings some Christian by to let us know that what we have done is sin, when God begins to work in our life like that, don't rebel against His chastising. Don't say to God, "Now wait a minute, this is too tough, I don't want to listen." Don't turn your back on God, don't try to walk away from God. Don't despise what God is doing in your life. Because when God knocks on your door and God says, "There is something wrong," and you slam the door in His face, God is going to come back. And He is going to knock a little bit harder the next time. If necessary, God is able to kick the door down at your house. That is not what He wants to do. The only reason that happens is because we rebel against Him when He tries to get us back into a place of fellowship.

The second truth is **God desires to restore you, not to punish you.** Notice what He says there in verse 6, "*For whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth, and scourgeth every son whom he receiveth.*" God loves the person He is chastening. Do you remember when you used to get spanked as a child? You would go back into your bedroom when it was all over and you would think, "Boy, what a mean, terrible Dad I have." But eventually, as you got a little older and you looked back on the situation, you realized Dad wasn't mean and terrible, but rather Dad was loving and kind.

The truth of Scripture is, God loves us, and when He chastens us it is not because He likes to punish us. How many of you would love to see your children immediately admit when they do wrong and say, "I've sinned, I'm wrong," so that you could spare the rod?

The third truth we see is that **chastisement proves that you belong to God.** In verses 7 and 8 the Bible says, "*If you endure chastening, God dealeth with you as with sons; for what son is he whom the*

father chasteneth not? But if you be without chastisement, whereof all are partakers, then are ye bastards, and not sons."

I have a question: Since you have been saved, has there ever been a time when God has had to chasten you? If you say, "Oh, no, not me!" then you are not a child of God. You see, most Christians fear chastening. That is not my cry. I say, "God, I want to be whipped. Not with the big board. Just that still, small voice in the heart will be enough, just wake me up with that, and hopefully I'll listen. But, God, I do want that chastening in my life, because if You don't chasten me, then I don't belong to you."

If you think about it, the reason God doesn't whip you is because you aren't one of His children. God only whips His own. You must belong to the other father who is the father of most of the people in this world, if you are not chastened. That would mean that you are a child of the devil according to John 8:44. So, thank God there is chastening for the child of God.

The fourth truth is **God wants submission**. What God really desires is here in verse 9, *"Furthermore we have had fathers of our flesh which corrected us, and we gave them reverence: shall we not much rather be in subjection unto the Father of spirits, and live?"* God doesn't whip us just to whip us, but God whips us so that we will submit ourselves to Him and say, "All right, I'll allow You to be Lord in my life."

It is amazing how a board or a paddle or a rod or a belt in a child's life can immediately bring a child to place of saying, "Okay Dad, okay Mom, whatever you say I'll do it right now." It is not that the parents enjoy using that rod or that paddle, but the end result they want is that kind of submission to their authority. Ultimately, when

that child grows up, that child will transfer the submission of authority to parents to a submission of authority to God. That is our goal as parents.

What God is after when He chastises you and I is to bring us to a place where we submit to Him and submit to His truth. We should be willing to say, “All right, Lord, if that is your standard, I will live by it!”

Then, in verse 10, we have the fifth lesson, **God corrects us for our benefit**. *“For they verily for a few days chastened us after their own pleasure; but he for our profit, that we might be partakers of his holiness.”* And it is to our benefit to be holy. Friend, there is no reward to being off in sin and in wickedness. Those things bring punishment, death, and disaster.

The Scriptures say it is a terrible thing to fall into sin, and in Proverbs it says the way of the transgressor is hard. But for some reason, we build up the way of the transgressor as beautiful and glamorous. We watch them on the Hollywood screens, on the television set, and they say wickedness gets you ahead in the world. We see the ads and the billboards and the beautiful women and the handsome guys. They are smoking and drinking and we say, “Boy, look at what this will get you.”

But they don’t show you the picture of the guy who is eaten up with cirrhoses of the liver laying in the hospital, gasping for his last breath. He has lost his family, he has lost his children, he has lost his job and his respect. He lays there just wishing that somebody would come in and be his friend. They want you to believe that everything is going to be great if you drink like that.

They don't show you the picture of the fellow who smokes and smokes until his life is literally gone before his eyes and finally he wads up his cigarettes and throws them away in disgust as the doctor says, "You only have a short time to live. If you throw those cigarettes away you might add another month to your life." Finally he will wad them up and throw them away and say, "I wish I had quit long ago!" But you could not have told him that any earlier. The way of the transgressor is hard, friend. God is not out to try to make things worse for us. God chastises us for our benefit.

The sixth truth we see is that **God's chastisement brings us back into fellowship with Him.** In verse 11 he says, "*Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless, afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby.*" That is why God works in your life and mine and sometimes brings hard circumstances into our lives, to try to get our attention. It is not that God joys in whipping or spanking. But it is that God joys in bringing us back to a place where He can fellowship with us again. That is what He is after.

Christians Must Confess Their Sins

Number one, You will sin. Number two, You will be chastised by God. Number three, You must confess your sin. In Proverbs 28:13 we read, "*He that covereth his sins shall not prosper: but whoso confesseth and forsaketh them shall have mercy.*"

Specific sin demands specific confession. Suppose you commit some specific sin--you lie, you cheat, you steal--you do some specific sin and that gets you out of fellowship with God. The only thing that is going to put you back in fellowship with God is specific

confession. “Lord, I lied to Bill. Lord, I stole from my employer. Lord, I cheated on that test.”

It takes the specific confession to get specific forgiveness for a specific sin! Nothing less will do. God won’t take any of these half confessions people like to use with each other. “Well, if I have done anything to offend you, please forgive me.” That is no good. You have sinned and you need to admit what you did wrong.

God wants sins confessed, named one by one. God demands that we confess. When we confess, the word confess means, very simply, to agree with God. “Lord, I know this is against your will and I know it is wrong and I agree with you that it is wrong and I want to hate it like you hate it. I want it out of my life like you want it out of my life.” Some folks like to come to God and say, “Lord, I am really sorry I did that,” when what they really mean is, “Lord, I am sorry I have to face the consequences.” God understands your heart.

Some come to God and say, “Lord, please help me get over this sin,” but all the while they have that sin tucked away in their pocket and they know that as soon as they get out of the church house they are going to go right back to it again. I have seen Christians come and say, “Preacher, I want to get over my cigarettes.” They have them in their pocket, they won’t take them out of their pocket and throw them away because they know that as soon as they hop in the car headed back home they are going to pull it out, light up, and puff away again. They have made provision for the flesh. They have tried to say to God, “I am really sorry,” when they really aren’t.

God wants specific confession. There are two promises in I John 1:9, “*If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.*” To **forgive** means

that God puts it away, never to be remembered again. Now, He could remember it, if it were a matter of ability, but He can't remember it because it is a matter of His Word. That is what forgiveness is all about.

Then, He promises not only to forgive us our sins, but to **cleanse** us from all unrighteousness. To cleanse us means He is going to take that sin and help us to put it out of our lives. He promises the power needed, if we are serious about this confession business, to lay that sin aside and begin to walk with Him. Our lives will be cleaned up. Fellowship with God, then, can only be had if we are cleansed from our sin. You may have a relationship with God and be saved, but the only way you will ever have an intimate fellowship with God is if your sins are one by one confessed.

You will sin. You will be chastised. Those things are absolutes in the Christian life until you die. But number three, you must confess to restore your fellowship with God, and that is where most Christians fail.

CONCLUSION

I want to give you three thoughts in conclusion. **Number one, aim to confess your sin as soon as you realize you have sinned.** Make that your plan. "As soon as I sin, I need to confess." That ought to become a part of your life. Don't wait and pile up all your sins for the end of the day to confess. Confess them as soon as you realize you have sinned! "Lord, that was wrong."

Number two, set a time at the end of every day when you will examine the attitudes and the actions of the day in order to find

sin and confess it. I want to confess my sin moment by moment as I sin, but I also know that at the end of the day I need to stop and reflect on what all has happened today. Before I go to sleep that is one of things I do. I look back on the beginning of the day and I walk myself through everything I did during the day, and I think, “Now, where did I go wrong, where did I have a wrong attitude, where were some things that maybe were said in a wrong way, what did I do that was wrong, what opportunities did I miss?” and then I deal with those with the Lord. I confess them.

Number three, at the end of every month, you should have a season of time that you set aside. It doesn't have to be a very long period of time, but a period of time when you are going to walk through the whole month from the first of the month to the last day of the month. Ask yourself, “What did I do every day, are there any things that are standing out in my life of areas where I have failed God, areas I have sinned against God?” And every month, then, clean the calendar for the whole month. Take a hard look at your life. Maybe you want to do it every week, or bi-weekly. But take a season of time when you clean up, a period of time as well as a daily time, and get the big picture on it. As you do, God will bring things to your remembrance, things that are hindering your fellowship, and as He does, and as you confess, God will remove that thing. Your sins and your iniquities, as Isaiah 59:1-2 talks about, will no longer hide His face.

QUESTIONS ON CONFESSION

1. Can a believer ever lose his salvation according to John 10:27-29?
2. Even though salvation is forever, is it necessary to confess sins after we are saved? Why or why not?
3. Is it possible to sin as a Christian?
4. What type of Christian is it who knows the truth, but doesn't obey it? (I Corinthians 3:1)
5. Can a Christian be satisfied to sin?
6. What happens to a Christian who sins?
7. Is God exercising love when He chastises?
8. God chastens only those who belong to Him.
Circle One: TRUE or FALSE
9. "God doesn't whip us just to whip us, but God whips us so that we will _____ ourselves to Him."

10. Proverbs 28:13 tells us that the one who covers his sin shall not _____.

11. Specific sin demands specific _____.

12. What does the word “confess” mean?

13. Should you wait awhile after you have sinned to confess it?